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Eddie Marshall

Drummer Eddie Marshall was born in Springfield, Massachusetts on April 13, 1938. He has performed with a long list of major jazz artists on both coasts and his name has become associated with San Francisco jazz. Eddie has also distinguished himself as a composer, band leader and performer on the alto recorder. He was honored at the San Francisco Jazz Festival in November of 2000.

Eddie was interviewed in San Francisco, California on August 8, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in San Francisco filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm extremely pleased to have Eddie Marshall with me today, who is a drummer and composer and recordist.

EM: Exactly

MR: We call you a recordist. Well it's a pleasure to have you here.

EM: Well it's a pleasure to be invited here.

MR: You were just talking before we were rolling about San Francisco has a fairly healthy music scene.

EM: A very healthy music climate here. I feel a very healthy jazz climate. This isn't the jazz center of the world but a lot of these young musicians, who some of them I had the pleasure of teaching and they've gone off to schools like the New School in New York and Berklee School of Music, a lot the East Coast schools, they've come back to San Francisco and they are working all over the place. And they are very fine musicians. It's not like a jazz mecca, it's more like a world music mecca if anything, in this area.

MR: Yeah. When I look in the newspapers I see a lot of different kinds of things happening. You have an Asian community here obviously that adds its own flavor.

EM: It's own flavor, yep, to the jazz music. It is quite amazing how these people from different backgrounds and different ethnic persuasions with their own musical history and how jazz music just fits in with all of these different musics. I just got back from Spain about a month or so ago. I was in the Basque country, and I hear this music, and I can't even pronounce the gentleman's name, but there was music that was Basque folk songs but played in the flavor of like Weather Report or something like that. And it was just amazing. And all over the world it's like that. You go to West Africa, that's a big example, you know the harmonies, it's no more like the African really simple chords and they're just like full blown modern, contemporary musicians playing a jazz version of their ethnic music, and just really killing it. I mean I'm sort of like dismayed at the music — I can't even call it a phenomenon — but the music trend that's going on now with the

hip hop music. And it's not to put down a music, because I don't believe there's any music there to put down. The concern I have is that these children, there is a generation of children in America, not just black kids but children in general, growing up without hearing a melody or a chord, or even a lyric. They're hearing —

MR: Beat only.

EM: Beats, a very basic bass line but nothing musical. And that really is worrisome to me. Because even in the days of rock & roll when rock & roll was first introduced, you know it was blues oriented. It had a melody. It had definite chords, even if there were only three of them.

MR: Right. There was a structure there.

EM: So that concerns me. And not that I don't appreciate the youth in America. You know a lot of it is age too. I mean sometimes I sound like my dad. Because I grew up living with, you know my family is very, very musical. And my dad plays and my mom played the piano, everybody played the piano. And he was into Teddy Wilson, and Art Tatum, Nat King Cole, who I love too. But I was into bebop music when I was a teenager. I loved bebop music. And I'll never forget that I was watching my father and we went to a party and he sat in and he's playing Teddy Wilson and I'm in the crowd and I'm hearing these guys say, "Man he's really a good piano player but you know, that's that old fashioned shit, I like bebop." And I did too. And sometimes I think like some of the criticisms that we older people have with the kids music is like maybe a little sour oats or whatever.

MR: I think some things never change.

EM: Because I try to guard myself against that, but the facts speak for themselves. I mean I turn on the radio and I'm telling you, I get more enjoyment out of listening to country western music and Gospel music. The Gospel music I hear on Sunday mornings, especially coming from some of the churches in L.A., I mean they have these bands that Earth, Wind and Fire would have to really stay on their toes to approach their musicality. It's really true and it's just great singing. And they're all kids from these schools, you know these young kids. A lot of the black kids go to the southern schools, Morehouse and oh I forget some of the schools, and they are really trained musicians, and it really shows.

MR: Well along with sounding like your parents, I kind of wonder too about we have a whole generation of kids who don't listen to music without a video image.

EM: Exactly.

MR: That part bothers me a little bit too.

EM: Yes. And the images that they show, it's so frustrating, it's like they flash this — just shifts from one — it never settles on anything, like a conspiracy theory — it leads me to think that they're just zapping, you know Nike's just subliminally zapping a message to these kids that they'll take a programmer to deprogram their life.

MR: Well music seems to be a family institution for you.

EM: Yeah.

MR: Your grandfather was a musician is that right?

EM: Yeah. Well my grandfather, now this is the point, Kaiser Marshall, well you know that's like a rumor.

MR: Is that right?

EM: Yeah. Because you know who first told me that was Art Blakey. Art Blakey used to accompany — and I knew Art before — but he says, "You know you've got a grandfather named Kaiser Marshall." I says, "Well I don't know, man." Because the fact was that I never knew my father's father. There was a big cloud of mystery around it.

MR: I see.

EM: And so I don't know that got out and stuff like that.

MR: Yeah it sure did.

EM: And people were telling me like, "Your grandfather, Kaiser Marshall, he invented the hi hat" and he did all this stuff. And you know it's just like rumor.

MR: Is that right?

EM: But and Art was like, he was pushing it himself. I'd never told any people anything like that. Anyhow what I did, I hired — I actually got my brother that lives in Massachusetts to get somebody to go back.

MR: A genealogist or one of them people?

EM: Yeah. And it was — Kaiser was born — the dates just didn't add up or something.

MR: Okay. But did you ever play with your father?

EM: Oh yeah. Oh boy. I mean that's how I started playing music. I started playing, I always took piano lessons. Like if you have a dad and mom and aunts, it's either guitar or piano, and back in those days you were like really country if you played the guitar. If you were a black kid playing guitar, forget it. I didn't want that image, I was too cool for that. I didn't want to play the piano either but there was nothing I could do. So like from 10 to 14, that's what I did, I took piano lessons. And I really enjoyed it. It was classical piano. But my dad always had rehearsals at the house, from the time I can remember. And of course when the drummer got off the drums I would jump on there. Even though I was six years — then they'd throw me off. But I kept on, I was just fascinated, during the rehearsals, I never even thought about it after rehearsal, but while we were there, I don't know if I was trying to get my dad's attention, but by the time I was 14, I could actually play the beats that they played. It was like a dance band. And they worked at the Westover Air Force Base and stuff like that and wore suits and all this. So there was one time, the drummer, Tommy, Tommy Johnson I believe his name was, he had trouble with his alimony payments. And they got a call the police were going to come and get him.

Anyhow he split and left the drums there. And then my dad was stuck. So I said, "Hey dad, you know, I know all these songs." I was 14 and I was still in junior high school. And I was at an Air Force base with my dad and so I started doing these gigs at the Air Force base with my music teacher, because there was a young music teacher in the schools in Massachusetts during those days, the forties and fifties, you had a music teacher. And this guy played the trumpet in my dad's band. So it was like a real secret that this 14-year-old kid's playing in the band. And that's how I started off. And I kept my day job, I kept my paper route.

MR: Don't quit your day gig yet.

EM: Don't know how this is going to go.

MR: But when you say a dance band, at that time, what would the repertoire have included?

EM: Okay it would be like all the standards. That's why I knew every standard in the world up until the 1950s. Anything like that, Duke Ellington "Take the A Train," Count Basie like, oh I mean every tune you could think of, the music of the forties basically.

MR: Okay. Any rhythm & blues yet?

EM: Well that, not in my dad's band. My dad was one of these bands that, he made money, because he played like these officers, and they they'd do like these weddings and stuff and we all had the suits on. It was very — I only knew like four beats, that's all you needed.

MR: You needed a two-beat and you need a swing—

EM: A swing and something Latin which was always [scats] — it was just terrible. I never heard or seen a Latin band, but I heard it on the radio and everything. And so I did that and then my Uncle Cookie, who had a band called the Seven Sharps, this was when I was in high school, I was 16 then, and I played with his band at a club. My mom actually let me go to this club called the Horseshoe in Springfield, Mass, and play drums with my Uncle Cookie. Now this was an R&B band. And this club, the Horseshoe, you have to realize everything was segregated back in those days you know. And so all the black folks were down on the south end. And I worked there with my uncle that first night and I was just totally gone. There was a fight, there was like everything. It was a totally all black club. And one of those types of places. It was just a hoot. You just could not believe it. And the music was just killing. Because it's R&B and I really, really liked that. So I didn't work for my dad anymore after that. And it went from like we were making like, I was making twenty dollars a night with my dad and eleven dollars a night with Cookie at the Horseshoe. But it was three nights in a row. And actually it ended up, by the time I left high school, four nights. And I did that for like two or three years and of course I never went to school on Friday, and I never went to school on Monday.

MR: I was going to say.

EM: And I had one of the lowest grade point averages ever recorded in the school history. But by that point I was totally obsessed with music. And it was just being in that environment. And I mean playing dance music, I mean that's what the whole thing is. It was never — I never had the mentality of being like a drum star, even though in those days my hero was Gene Krupa. Because that's how I really started liking drums anyhow, by going to the movies and seeing the old news reels of Benny Goodman and Gene Krupa. And he just — I even got to take a lesson with him.

MR: No kidding.

EM: Yeah. It was like the highlight of my life.

MR: He was a nice man, wasn't he?

EM: Oh, a beautiful man. A beautiful guy. I felt so bad for him because he used to play at the Metropole — I don't know if you knew about the Metropole.

MR: I've heard about it.

EM: There was like, they had all these, like George Wettling, all these old drummers who were like the baddest dudes in the world, but it was like in the fifties and bebop ruled. And they would play at the Metropole in the window, like they were like mannequins. And that's the part I didn't like. And like in the afternoon like Gene would play there like sometimes five to eight. And it was like, I don't know it was like very demeaning.

MR: Didn't they have a long bar, a long stage behind the bar or something.

EM: Yeah, yeah, yeah. It was, I don't know, anyhow so I started playing with Cookie and the Seven Sharps and Cookie is still alive, he's like eighty something years old. And that was it. And I Just stayed with that until I was 18. And then I had an uncle, my Uncle Roddy, who got drafted into the Army. Actually he got drafted into the Marines during the Korean War which was really — I think he was drafted and they gave him a choice or something. But he ended up a draftee in the Marines. And he was a jazz fanatic. So he left, you know I was the only one he could leave his records with, and they were all jazz records. There was "Charlie Parker with Strings," I think it was Max Roach — no it was "Milestones," the old "Milestones," with Miles and Sonny Rollins, and there was another one — "The Modern Jazz Quartet" or something. Anyway well I heard Miles Davis and that did it. I was totally gone for jazz. I couldn't play with Cookie anymore. Because, you know I remember the last few jobs I played with Cookie I was so obsessed with bebop I'm trying to play bebop in the rhythm & blues tunes. And they are looking at me, you know there's a groove. First of all I didn't fit, and I didn't even know how to do it right anyway.

MR: That's so interesting that you got pulled out of your father's mode into this thing, and then out of that thing.

EM: Yeah. No mind of my own. Totally susceptible to really out stuff. But I was. And then after that I was on a quest. I knew I had to leave Springfield and go to New York. Around that same time was when Clifford Brown and Richie Powell died. And I had gotten tickets to go to The Music — well it was in Lenox, Massachusetts — The Music Barn. And they used to have these great festivals. But it was way out in the boondocks, it was like you had to take a bus and all that stuff. Anyhow Max was playing there and then I didn't know that Clifford had died, and I got up there and instead of Clifford they had Kenny Dorham and Sonny Rollins, which they were very killing too.

MR: Not bad.

EM: And I'll never forget, my bus left at 11:30 and it was fifty miles from Springfield. Now I had to either leave in the middle of the set and miss the last part of it, or hitchhike in the dark home. And I hitchhiked in the dark home. I did. It was cold and I'll never forget that. It was totally worth it.

MR: Paying your dues already.

EM: I did. I'd heard Max on the records and I'm trying to do his stuff by just listening to it, and of course I had it all wrong. And after I got to see him I could see how he was really doing stuff like [scats] you know there was a way that Max hits each drum, and you couldn't tell it from just listening like we did in those days. I did a lot of listening.

MR: Wow. That's interesting. And you finally got to New York and found yourself in that scene.

EM: Oh man, I went to New York, it was terrible. After being such a big cheese in Springfield, Mass you know, I'll never forget I got off the — well actually I went to New York first without my drums. I stayed with my aunt who lives in Franklin Roosevelt Apartments way on the lower East Side. And she had two kids, I'll never forget it, and they were just all over me. They thought they were going to have a big brother or something, I was 17, 18 years old. And so I couldn't do that. I left there. The fact is I went to New York I had a hundred and twenty-five dollars. And I left that place, I went to the Y, I got a room at the Y, I got a job the next day because I had experience as a printer, from my uncle who owned a printing shop, and I got a job not as a printer but as a messenger — one of those guys that runs the messages all over Manhattan you know. So I had that. And I started taking lessons but I didn't have any jobs or anything. And I was just totally threatened by every drummer I saw in New York because they were all so good. I went to a club on Eighth Avenue right across the street from the bus station, and heard this trio and the drummer was so good, I mean I said oh boy, I've really got a lot to learn, because it was amazing. And I started taking lessons at Manhattan School of Music with Jim Chapin. And I started getting pretty good but just totally, you know New York was just another story. And I ended up going to a school called the Hartnett School of

Music. It was a GI bill school. You know it gets kids getting out of the Korean War, they had the GI bill and people were going into music. And it was on 42nd Street. And that's when I started meeting musicians and getting a little more into it and I met Art Taylor and he invited me to go to these sessions. He used to have these sessions in the East Village that, you know after the gigs ended at three or four in the morning then they'd go to these sessions and play until seven. And I really didn't really do too much. We formed bands out of the school and we worked. We would get like a quartet together then we'd go out to Coney Island, especially during the summertime, and tell the guy — go into a club and say lookit, let's play here for the weekend — we'll play one night for free and see how it goes. So we'd play like a Thursday or Friday night for free, then on the weekends we'd get paid. And maybe this gig would last like two or three weeks and then we'd move on like that. And I was doing that. And I went back home to Springfield. And one thing I remember, I would go to all the clubs, you know Birdland and Basin Street and the Half Note, then had a million clubs in New York. And there was one place called the Hickory House that I would walk by and I would see this Japanese woman playing the piano. And she was like this gorgeous girl with this really, really, really long hair, who could really play the piano. Because there was a couple of other women that played but it was like cocktail stuff. And Jake Hanna was playing with her. And it was Toshiko. So you know I would go there and listen sometimes and I was really enthralled with her, she was really cute. And everybody in New York was. But it was one of these phenomenons, she was a really cute woman but could she play, boy. So anyhow I'm in New York and I was — no I was back in Springfield and I heard that Toshiko and Charlie Mariano, who was her husband, were looking for a drummer. And they were playing in Hartford. So I drove down to Hartford, I said, "I used to see you all the time when I was delivering stuff I'd come by, going to Birdland or something." And she was always very nice and Charlie was just like a wonderful man. And anyhow I auditioned for her and I got the job.

MR: Wow.

EM: And I've been working ever since. And with Toshiko every now and then.

MR: Yeah. I know. I have one of your recordings. Do you go to Japan every year with her?

EM: Almost every year except for these last few years I mean since the economy's been so bad. We didn't go this year.

MR: Did you play during your Army service? Were you able to play?

EM: Yeah. Well I played a little bit. I played in an Army band but I was — by the time — I got drafted into the Army. I was living in New York as a young man and having problems with drugs, and hit sort of like a rock bottom. And when I got drafted, there were like all soldiers and I wanted to get out of, whatever. You couldn't get out of Basic.

I didn't know anything about anything that was going on in the world when I got drafted. This was like '62. I was just so totally involved with myself and music, that I didn't know there was a war going on in Vietnam or it was something I didn't really pay much attention to, politics and all that stuff. And so I got in the Army, I did get in a band, I was at Fort Dix, New Jersey, but something was happening. It was something in the air like in '63, we started getting all of these Asian officers coming to Fort Dix. And that meant every time they came in town we had — there was a concert band. You played in the jazz band, but you were part of the concert band also. And then you didn't get any leaves. You were playing, you know, whatever, the National Anthem was for these different officers. And so I know now they were just building up for the war, you know, and having these people coming over here and there is a fanfare. And then the band, which was good, but we just played dances. We were playing all these Woody Herman things and it was like USO clubs, Philly and New York, mostly Philly and New York. And I just opted out. And so I told the Warrant Officer Brown, look I've got to get out of this. And they were going to have some of us march too, that's what really did it. And so I got out and I went into Field Artillery. Because I knew I'd be out in the woods and I loved that. To this day I love it. My kids, some of them hate me for the things I brought them through. Every year we'd go camping.

MR: Going camping and stuff? Yeah?

EM: And now the grandkids love it though.

MR: Good. Well you have some people to go with you now.

EM: But I did, I went into that. Actually the Army was good for me, it really was. It totally cleaned up my act. And I got out in '64, in '65 I joined Stan Getz' band and did that for a year. Well no, what did I do after that? Oh yeah and after that I worked with Dionne Warwick. I did that for almost two years.

MR: She was in a very high period in her career, right?

EM: Oh boy, that was really — because then I was back in R&B again, which was really — oh I thought oh this, in R&B I was making more than eleven dollars a night. She was a sweetheart, I mean boy oh boy, was she ever a nice woman. Because I had my first wife, she was — sometimes Dionne would just take her along with us. And we traveled all over the place. And great shows. We'd do these shows with Stevie Wonder and Gladys Knight & the Pips and Wilson Pickett, Al Green, all of these really heavy soul acts. And it was just wild. And really nice people, it's amazing, because most of those people on those tours are church people. So they traveled with their moms and Dionne traveled with her mom half the, most of the time.

MR: Neat.

EM: It was. It was pretty wholesome.

MR: You're getting back in the other direction now.

EM: Yeah and the thing it was though, it was like you get into it so much and there's a whole different life. Everybody's like you don't even set up your own drums and you don't do anything. You just sit there and you play. And you're just playing the same songs over and over and over again, so you get really good at playing those songs, but then when you try to play something else it was like really foreign, the movements. The drums are very — it's this coordination. And so one style of music demands a different set of coordination. And it was really wild.

MR: Did you stop doing that because it got repetitious or was it just kind of came to —?

EM: Well two reasons I stopped. It was really good music, I mean Burt Bacharach wrote beautiful songs for Dionne, "Anyone That Had a Heart" and great tunes. I mean really, musically, rhythmically, everything, I loved playing that music. Then she recorded "Do You Know the Way to San Jose." So she was laughing about it, I didn't do any recordings, we were the road band. And she brings this song to the rehearsal and said, "You guys are going to die after this." We recorded this and it was really doing great in some parts of the country, she's always talking like it's doing this — and I said "Dionne," I said, I didn't tell her like that, but I told her I said, "You know if this tune ever becomes a hit I'm out of here."

MR: No kidding.

EM: Because it was like — rickey tickey. Well it becomes a hit and we're playing it every night. You know and my wife was pregnant at the time and we were in L.A., and I said we couldn't go back she was having a baby any minute so I said well I'm quitting. So I quit in L.A. And we stayed out here. We had the baby, we were in L.A. and I just never went back to the East Coast. I mean I go back and everything but I just — it was just a different world. First it was a lot of space and I grew up back east and I felt really, I could really breathe out here. And I really liked the temperament of the people. I thought the people were a lot more open on the West Coast than they were here, so a lot of different things. And it was the sixties, so you know it was, it was just like pretty wild. I mean you had the heavyweight black politics on one side, you have the hippies over here burning down Berkeley — really — all this different flow of music that was happening, a real strong Latino thing. I never knew any Latino people on the East Coast, not really.

MR: Those circles never mixed.

EM: No I was just totally on a bebop thing and out here I met people — you know Asians playing jazz, and playing their own music. It really opened my eyes. I just really — and plus I could hike. I could get out, I could just drive fifty miles and be in the wilderness. And that's still one of the things that I can't wait — even when I go anywhere I can't wait to get back here, the little secret places I go, I've got my kayak.

MR: A great hobby.

EM: I've got my grandsons who love to fish. What more could I ask for?

MR: Great.

EM: And I have a new set of Sonar drums.

MR: It looks like you're in the pink.

EM: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have to do anything for living along the way besides playing drums?

EM: Oh yes. But let me tell you, like okay. My wife, my present wife of 21 years now, had two children when we met. I had three. All boys. Five boys. And I'll never forget — and most of the time I was on the road, that's how I made my money. So as long as I was on the road all the time I could do okay. So I didn't have any really ridiculous habits, I just sent my money home. And it worked out all right. Anyhow Sue is new to all of this, and she's got the five boys, their ages of like at that time they were like 3 to maybe like 12. All boys. So I left, I went with Bobby, we went to Europe. I come back and Sue says, "Never again." It was just crazy. Because these five boys, they bonded like this. You know sometimes you hear like families get together and there's all this fighting. Well they were like bamm, and they still are. But to the detriment of Sue mainly, because being the only woman there.

MR: One against five.

EM: So I couldn't leave. And there was no way I could make enough money in town. So I started my own handyman business with construction. I had a buddy who — Jessie Flurry — who was, like myself, very good with his, you know, carpentry and stuff like that. And this friend of ours owns property in San Francisco, a lot of buildings and stuff. And he always needs — somebody needs a door put on or somebody wants cabinets or somebody wants — there's a leak in the ceiling because somebody ran the tub over. So that's what we did. It was our own company. We hired our boys. The older boys all worked with me. And I did that for like five years, until the older ones got in college, and then it just was a little easier. When I first moved out here I was on the road so much I didn't even know anybody in San Francisco hardly.

MR: Sure.

EM: And so I did that and to tell you the truth we did pretty well too, made a lot of money. And the kids learned how to work. They are musicians too. Three of my kids play music. And it's amazing because sometimes I'll go by a house or something where I built a fence, sometimes I'd build fences. And I'd say, "See that fence over there?" "Yeah daddy, we know."

MR: Do they listen to your records?

EM: The boys do, yeah, they listen to them, but they didn't ever play that type of music. My kids were, even my stepchildren were like totally into Mick Jagger and Paul Butterfield and all those. And my kids were like into Cameo and Earth Wind & Fire. But they all play like guitars and bass and drums, so I always had a band in the house, you know. In fact when I had like an R&B gig I would just hire them, because they could play it better than any of the jazz musicians.

MR: Sure. Yeah that can be funny sometimes, hearing straight jazz people trying to play some rock & roll.

EM: I know it. Because I tried to play in their band and they're all over me and we had a little hip hop band together. And none of them — Al plays drums, my oldest son. But he wanted to play keys, but he played everything. So I played with them for a while. And I can do it for a while, and I can keep the pocket going, but I've got to always put something extra — so I'd be like [scats] and as soon as I did it they turned around. And I said oh man, forget it. But they really still are good musicians, those kids, they could play like before they heard Michael Jackson. This is a funny story too because before they heard Michael Jackson the only thing they ever heard in my house was just jazz but mostly Trane and Miles, and songs that I wrote. And so I bought the kids like a Beatles bass. Andre wanted to play the bass. So he was like eleven years old and he could hardly even get his arm up there but he just kept on doing it and he could actually play. And they were uncorrupted by time signatures. So if I wrote a song that was in 7/8 and I'd say, "Andre just go like this" [scats], he didn't count, he would just do it. And it would amaze my jazz friends because I would write those tunes and ask them to play it and they could not play it, because they're counting.

MR: Right. This is too odd.

EM: Yeah. But they got pretty good. And like the two that were really pulled were Al and Reven, the one that liked rock & roll, and Al who liked R&B. They auditioned for the same blues band when they were older and they both got on the band. It was amazing. And they traveled. And my kids are interracial kids, you know, and they were traveling with this black singer in the south. And Reven is my wife's son, and he's white. And Al looks like he's from, I don't know, Al looks like either Spanish or Arab, you know he doesn't really fall — and so they're playing all these black clubs and the girls are coming on to him and they don't know what they are. And they tell them they're brothers. "Oh y'all ain't brothers." "Yeah we are." And they would tell me all their war stories. It was really cute.

MR: Well this was — what year are you talking about now?

EM: This was like in '85 until about '90.

MR: Okay. Because we kind of skipped over — I wanted to talk about the Fourth Way.

EM: Oh boy. Well that's another reason I stayed on the West Coast so long. Because actually after I came out here with Dionne and everything and I was in L.A. — L.A. I couldn't really hang because L.A. is more like a recording industry and I've always played live music. So we were going to leave L.A. actually and go back to New York, when the baby was like a few months old. But Mike Nock, who was the piano player with Dionne, he had moved out to the West Coast. He had left Dionne's band before I did. And he went to the West Coast, he ended up in San Francisco and worked with John Handy. And all this was going — there was a West Coast scene going on, but I didn't know it, I'm back — and he says well before you go back, I'm going to start a band, me and Michael White are going to start this band, just come up and see if you want to deal with it. You can stay at Michael White's house, you don't have to pay rent and stuff. So we drove up here, and Michael White was living in Oakland, and we start, this was the Fourth Way. Well I started really enjoying living in San Francisco because I had never played any really like rock & roll type music, I'd played R&B but this was more like rock and jazz. And I remember I was still smoking cigarettes and I remember like the first week or so, you're just playing really hard all the time and I'm going [pants] and I quit smoking, I quit this twenty year smoking habit, because I was just getting pooped. And the band actually took off and we played a lot of clubs here and oh the guy Bill Graham, that whole scene was starting, and he sort of liked that band. And we got hired to play a lot of opening acts at the Fillmore. We'd open for the Grateful Dead, we'd open for Miles one time, we opened for — a whole lot of different bands. But the one that was most important, we opened for Santana. And Santana really liked us so he took us on tour with him, I mean we went to Europe to the Montreux Jazz Festival with Santana, and I've always respected that guy since forever, because he always gives like jazz players a break to make money you know what I mean? He thinks that we ain't making anything, so, even to this day he still does stuff like that. And so the band took off, and that lasted like three or four years, and living in the Bay Area and I just sort of got used to living here, then I'm working out of here every now and then, and then I still thought I might go back, because you always get that feeling you know. Because my family's back east and everything. Then the Keystone Club opened, the Keystone opened up. And so I'm working there, me and James Berry and basically it was the rhythm section from Bobby Hutcherson's band. I started working with Bobby around that time also. And we worked at the Keystone, we were like the house band, George Cables and I forget the bass player's name already, anyhow we were like a house trio there. And there was no reason to leave then because all the guys that I would be working for in New York, they were all coming here. And so James Leary was the bass player. And so that lasted for five years. By that time I was too old to go back.

MR: You'd established yourself in the area.

EM: Yeah, oh boy.

MR: Yeah, a long list of people came through there. Any people stand out in your memory in particular?

EM: Oh I mean some people stand out, you know even if I'd never worked with them but Dexter Gordon was one of them. He really was a bigger than life person. But a lot of great musicians. Art Farmer, there was a particularly nice evening with Art Farmer and Clifford Jordan, it was just — they were both wonderful people but what great players. And there's so many different players.

MR: Was Dexter as —

EM: Ebullient? You know one thing? I would go to Europe, me and Bobby — I worked with Bobby Hutcherson, mostly in the seventies, and we'd go to Europe a lot. And Dexter lived in Europe then. And he was the king of Europe, I am telling you. Everywhere Dexter played it'd be thousands of people. And he was just always real, and he's just so tall and he was just so striking. And he would stay very, very polite and if he was going to play a song "Over the Rainbow" he'd say "Somewhere— Over the Rainbow — Way—" he'd say the first few lines of the song and especially if it was a ballad, then he had this big tone and all of a sudden, he would just knock you out. It was amazing. He was just like that. And I worked with him when he first came back and he didn't have his regular band. And we went to Canada and different places. But so many, there were so many good musicians there. Everybody that came through there boy.

MR: Well I see one of my other favorite people on here and that is Jon Hendricks.

EM: Oh boy, yeah. Now Jon Hendricks is a true living genius. I worked with Jon in "Evolution of the Blues," that was in the seventies also. And I'll never forget one episode with Jon, there was some kind of tension between the dancers and Jon and whatever, anyway it ended up I sort of sided with the dancers. And Jon, it was sort of like a walk-out. And there was like a musician/dancer strike, like that. So we said we weren't going to do the show until certain demands were met. Jon said, "Well I'll do the show myself." So I said oh I've got to see this. So I go to see the show myself. Jon did "Evolution of the Blues" all just about solo. And killed it. It was just wonderful. It really was. I mean he is such a genius. And you know — I don't know, have you ever seen him on stage? There's something about his face. He has a perfect stage presence. And he's totally focused. I mean I've watched this man a lot of times and he is totally focused. And just this energy exudes from him, even when he's scatting. He's probably only scat singing that you can really understand most of the time, and he mouths, it's not just baloney sounds, he pays attention to the chord structure of his tones. He's just amazing. But his diction and his timing on everything, and I mean he is like an amazing person. I just can't —.

MR: Yeah. He's very articulate and spiritual.

EM: A total character. He's a wild man. Maybe he's a little calmer these days, but he's very excited. He loves jazz man. And you can tell the people that really love this music. They just exude it.

MR: Yeah.

EM: But he was pretty amazing.

MR: Well the San Francisco community seems to have embraced you as an institution.

EM: Oh yeah. It's either that or I should be institutionalized. No I mean it's like a mutual love affair. You know it's a situation where like I moved out here with no immediate family here, but I have a great family here, a family of friends and musicians that I have met here who really support me and jazz music in general. They really do. A lot of these club owners, they make a strong effort to keep jazz in San Francisco. There's no real major jazz club in San Francisco. You know there's no Keystone anymore. The major jazz club in this area is Yoshi's, which is a very fine club. They keep the banner waving by bringing acts from all over the world into Yoshi's. But we don't have — we have the alternative, which is a pretty good alternative, is our year round San Francisco Jazz Festival at [inaudible], which nobody gave a prayer to when it first — I mean this thing, a jazz festival all year round in a city of less than 700,000 people. But it's working. He's a busy person.

MR: I see you've even been to Beijing?

EM: I went to Beijing with my friend Jon Jang, which is a perfect example of the openness I found here on the West Coast, like with the Asian Jazz Society and people who are Asians, they're saying lookit, man, we've been playing this music since it began too. There were jazz bands in China in the forties. This isn't like something that's foreign to them. We've been living with you maniacs all these years so we are authentic jazz musicians. And so Jon is one of these guys.

MR: What's his name now?

EM: Jon Jang.

MR: Jang?

EM: Jang. J-A-N-G. And he goes between a love for his Chinese music and a love for Duke Ellington and modern jazz music and he plays with people like David Murray and all of these — and so we went to Beijing for some kind of — I don't know how they got us over there, it was some kind of basic Beijing Jazz Festival, which was only attended by the very rich, like a one time event. There's a lot of those in different parts of the world, where the aristocrats or the ruling people, they like jazz and they have enough money to import it. And it was a very interesting experience. I really love Beijing, I'll tell you that. I mean the people there were just wonderful. Boy oh boy. A nation that understands the meaning of a nice hug.

MR: Oh yeah?

EM: They do. They'll give you a hug, the young kids and it's really great. I really enjoyed it over there. And it's sort of — I went to Tiananmen Square and it was sort of, there was a big tension with the soldiers, because the soldiers there, you know like our soldiers here, at least you can say, "Hey how you doing, buddy?" Their soldiers are really stiff and really rigid and you don't fool around with them at all. You don't have conversation. But the people are just very friendly and want to know where you're from and da-da-da. And maybe like fifty yards away from the center of Tiananmen Square there's a McDonald's. The Golden Arches are everywhere. So you're not totally away from home.

MR: Yeah. Tell me about your composing if you would. When did you start writing?

EM: Well you know I was always encouraged to compose. I showed an interest in it with everybody I ever worked with. For most of my jazz life I had to read music and stuff like that, but they were other people's compositions. And the first person who encouraged me to write music actually was Mike Nock. Because I always played this recorder. It was an instrument I was introduced to when I was 16. But I played mostly bebop and I would compose tunes and Mike Nock liked one of the tunes. And he said, "You know you ought to write that down." And I started, that was like in the late sixties. And so I've been writing ever since then. And I've had some things recorded — Johnny Griffin recorded one of my tunes, and Bobby Hutcherson recorded a few of them, and it's what I like to do musically when I'm not playing.

MR: Does a tune usually start with the recorder?

EM: Sometimes it starts — it the early days it started with the recorder. Now it starts a lot, mostly with chord progressions a lot of the times. I got into theory and harmony with a lot of different musicians. First with my dad, you know, I did want to know what he was doing. I was a piano player too for a while, you know, I took piano lessons and stuff. And I've always messed around with the piano. But voicings have always fascinated me. You know I remember the first time someone showed me how to do alternate voices, it was just like one-three-five and then he'd go three-five-one or five-three — you know. And that just led, the voicings. And then I started playing with Bobby Hutcherson, who was like — actually I'd have to say he was my theory teacher and still is. Because he is just so knowledgeable and always so willing to show me how these chords move and how this scale goes with that you know, and stuff I would never learn if I went to school. Because he always was patient. And I would go back and try this and then write. And I still have a lot of stuff that I wrote twenty years ago, thirty years ago. And now I use the computer. I'm computerized. So now I'm writing this piece, I'm trying to get grants. I still love to write jazz pieces but now I'm writing on, I got sort of interested in Baroque music in the last twenty years or so. And I'm writing this music for two tenor recorders, oboe and

cello. And it's going to be — I'm trying to get a grant to do this. And it's going to be a suite. And then on some of the pieces I'm going to add like percussion, bass and piano. And I'm really excited about this because this is the first time I've done something like this.

MR: Sounds like an interesting combination of sounds.

EM: Yeah. And it really sounds good. It's different, and the venues I'm choosing to do it in, like in San Francisco they have a lot of functions at churches, some of the old wooden churches. There's a church here in the city called Old First Church where they do concerts with small ensembles and stuff like that.

MR: Yeah. Has the scene between musicians and — has the racial scene between musicians changed over the years? Or was it ever an issue at all?

EM: Oh it's always an issue. This is America. It's always an issue. It's either white musicians feel that the record companies are slamming them because they just want to record black musicians — that was a thing a few years ago. And it was probably true too for the record companies. I mean I don't know if I want to even go there. I mean because it's like they use that thing where they're pushing young musicians and then pushing all black musicians — you know wherever the money flow goes, that's where the record companies go. Not to say that there's not a lot of good music being recorded. But a lot of it — but the racial thing, you know it's probably least — you know we're musicians, jazz musicians, I think we're probably wise enough now to know that neither of us are making any money. You know what I'm saying? Like I don't even see where that ever comes in. I mean it's like some people will ask me "oh is it better playing — do you like playing with white musicians better than you like playing with black musicians?" I mean you always get that. And it's like, I like playing with anybody. Now if somebody can't play, that's a different thing. You don't have to be black or white and be sad. I mean if you think of a thing of comfort now, now sometimes either you might think yeah, he sounds good, he's playing with all these black musicians. But those guys are probably all my old buddies that I've known forever and we have this comarad — there always is going to be this thing about, like if all Jewish people get together and you know you're in this family, you're having a ball, because you're enjoying each other, you're enjoying each other's Jewishness or whatever it is.

MR: Right. It's not just a musical issue.

EM: Right. Because when it gets down to that level, I don't have any greater pleasure than I did playing with my kids. It never gets that relaxed, playing with anybody. Because we've just done it so often and it's been so real and so — you know they're your kids. So it's a different thing. Now I played like last night, I played with this wonderful kid, Leonard Thompson. These kids, I mean I could be their grandfather actually. These kids

are maybe like 25, 30 years old, something like that. Really a great player. And the same with Jon, who is an Asian kid. But the thing is you can always tell when you're playing with any musician, you can hear, with the piano player, the sound that he gets on the piano. Like most of these kids, well most young musicians, it might be a lot of flash and everything because a lot of young kids can do that. But there's a sound that a jazz pianist emits and a feeling. And I always have to — what is that sound exactly? I say well anyone knows what that sound is on the piano, it's Hank Jones. Everybody knows that. I mean Herbie Hancock even knows that. It's just that sound, the feeling.

MR: Yeah.

EM: And with drums, I mean there's some people like I say it's like Elvin. Give me Elvin Jones, he's like — he's an old man, but he epitomizes like my era of drummers. Not that these kids aren't playing — I don't know if you know some of these guys like Billy Kilson and Billy Drummond and Gregory Hutchinson, these are these young kids that are demon drummers. And all of us, as soon as we listen to Elvin we have to go — and Max is another one. Still going. Max was at my house a couple of years ago, he was in town doing a recording so I invited him over the house. I had my drums set up in the living room and he sits down to play and I'm playing the piano and we're playing these blues and everything. And he's singing.

MR: Oh, gee.

EM: Really. He's getting pretty frail now but he's still — so I left him there playing, he's practicing on the drums. And I said, "Well Max I have to step out for a minute." So actually I just stepped out in the kitchen. And so he's playing. And he's just playing this stuff it's like — like when I'm practicing I'm always going [steady scat]. And he's going [rhythmic scat] he's playing all this stuff and it's like a half hour he's playing. So I left. Because he was just into it. And I came back and he was still playing. And then I come back and he says, "Oh man these drums sound great." And I said. "Well Max, why don't you come and sit in the back yard." I have a garden in the back you know. So I brought him in the back and the sun is shining and he lays back and he just fell dead asleep. And it was so nice to have this guy that's my hero.

MR: Did you tell him about the little thing?

EM: No I never didn't. I hope I'll see him again. He's a marvelous person.

MR: Some of those — there's people that you just — we were talking with Earl Watkins — that have a certain amount of class to them, it rubs off on you.

EM: Yea.

MR: You know like I always think of Milt Hinton and guys like that.

EM: Yeah I never got a chance to meet Milt Hinton.

MR: Yeah. But those are the kind of people that you feel better after you hang out with them.

EM: I know it. I know it. Oh boy. Bobby Hutcherson is another one. Bobby and McCoy Tyner — they seem to be two of the greatest improvisers that I can— You know if I think of pure improvising? And I'd have to add Herbie Hancock into that too. That they can just take, you know just bend harmony or whatever they do, everything is so pliable in their hands.

MR: I think I have a piece here that you played on.

[audio interlude]

EM: Oh yeah. We used to play this song a lot. That's with Manny. Is Manny Boyd on this I think?

MR: Oh could be. It's from '77?

EM: Oh yes. That's Manny Boyd.

MR: What kind of time are you used to, being in a studio to get in album done?

EM: You know in these days when we used to do these albums it would be like — first I would get there and Bobby would have nothing together. And we'd get there and rehearse the tunes and maybe we'd do it like in two days at the most. At the most. It's unbelievable how fast we used to do those. But we were playing all the time though.

MR: Yeah. I think Orrin Keepnews produced some of this stuff, didn't he?

EM: Yeah.

MR: What's your view on the outlook for jazz these days?

EM: Boy oh boy. You know I look at the percentages, I was looking at one of these music trade magazines that says what jazz music actually comprises, like less than three percent of the total sales. So I don't see any financial gain coming. But on the other hand the idea that it is now worldwide is just totally fascinating me.

MR: Yeah.

EM: That I can go anywhere in the world where there are young musicians who play jazz music and I don't even have to speak their language and we can play music together. And really play good music together too. I think that's about all you can expect from jazz music, it's a great communicator. It's the taste. As much as we love it as musicians, it's a taste for the listener and it's an addiction for the musicians. You know? Because there's no other — I couldn't ever take jazz music out of my life you know. My kids will always say, "Well dad I thought you said you were going to retire?" I say from what?

MR: Yeah. It's not work, right?

EM: No this is not work. I wake up every morning, I am just blessed. Sometimes I question, why did the Great Spirit give me this privilege of doing this and everybody's working their balls off these days. Why am I the lucky one? And my brothers. We're not especially nice people. We're no nicer than anybody else. What is it that got us into this

field of making music for people? Sometimes you get the sense people don't even want to hear music. But we still want to make it anyhow, what is that?

MR: It's interesting you say that. I wonder, you know in some sense music is all over the place, and sometimes I wonder if it's too much. Like it's in the grocery stores, you can't avoid it when you're walking down the street because someone's blaring it out of their car. And after a while it becomes not as special.

EM: Yeah. Well you know one thing? The strongest thing about that is a place like Brazil. Now you know I'm going to be guilty of saying good music and bad music, because most of the time in the grocery stores and stuff you're hearing bad music, I feel that anyhow. This is my opinion. And you hear elevator music, music with the drums etched out, or somebody in their car and you're not even hearing music you're hearing something going boom-boom and the car's jumping up and down. Where in Brazil you hear a Samba all the time. All the time. [scats] And you hear a guitarist. But the guitars are playing the most beautiful changes, even if it's some kid just sitting in Sao Paulo somewhere with no legs and playing the guitar, he's playing these gorgeous changes and stuff. He's not just going [scats]. And in Brazil it is, it's infectious. You talk about hearing it all the time, it's a way of life, it's the sound of the cities, the sound of Sao Paulo, and it's everywhere. It's just like you can hear the traffic, you can hear everything, but you hear it [scats] and it's totally amazing. I'll never forget in Brazil going to one of these favelas they have up in the hills and they don't have like bars and stuff it's like somebody has this great big box or something and he's there and people just come up, it's like a street bar. It's not enclosed all the way. But I was in one of those clubs, and everybody's playing this, they've got maracas and everybody jams and stuff. And one guy had a matchbox, one of those little wooden matchboxes with some of the matches taken out of it, and he's going chic-a-chica-a-chica-a-chica. But he was like a virtuoso. And then he would take his fingers and go [scats] and he's doing all this stuff with them. And then everybody gives each other five and a bunch of other guys will come in and start doing it. And of course drinking. They had this drink that was amazing. A sasha or something, it was like a lot of alcohol and a lot of sugar is how I remember. You would get stoned off this thing. But I mean jazz music, I just see it now as you know it's always going to be an element in American music, it's been such a strong statement from the beginning. But I see the jazz as salvation out of America. I mean it's — what do you call it — this intrusion into other people's music all over the world, it's the most exciting thing I feel that jazz is doing.

MR: Yeah. It's a great export for this country.

EM: Yeah.

MR: Do you have any interesting plans in the near future?

EM: Well actually I mean see another thing about this area, you can always re-invent yourself. Now I've been teaching a lot this past couple of years so I haven't really been playing out nights. There's a couple of groups I play with, one is the Bill Bell Trio. It's the Eddie Marshall Trio when it's my job and it's Bill Bell — and that's sounding like a straight ahead jazz trio. But I'm trying to put together an organ trio with organ, saxophone and drums. And that will probably be my next adventure. And plus writing for this ensemble, which that's going to take a lot of my time.

MR: Are you able to hear things back when you do the computer?

EM: Oh, well I am hooked up. I've got every modern gadget.

MR: No kidding.

EM: You know the thing is, when I was in high school, I went to a technical high school, took a technical course, it was electronics and carpentry and all of this sort of stuff. That's why I had my business. And so I bought a computer maybe like ten years ago, after swearing I would never use a computer. But ten years ago I bought a computer and I bought Performa, which is a sequencing program, and Encore, which is a music writing program, and a lot of manuals. And I sort of like mastered all of it, because I'm pretty clever at mastering stuff. So I have it now and I can play my music on the computer and it writes it out and I have scores and it looks pretty neat you know. And I'm always learning new programs. So really I am into the computer. Not that I do music for presentation but it's my tool at this point.

MR: Great. Well you've come a long way since you hitchhiked from Lenox, Mass. That's a great story.

EM: Well really it was music — music really allowed me to get out of Springfield and get out of New York. I mean I was a kid — sometimes I thought I would never get out of New York. Even though I loved it and everything, it's so huge and so intimidating at times, it's like, especially when I was living in Harlem. When you live in Harlem, though you love it and everything, you know people yourself who have never gotten out of there. So it's sort of like kind of am I in this situation? I mean I wasn't a rich college kid living in New York, I was just trying to struggle with making a living and learning how to play, and you sort of can get like whoa man, this is a little bit too big.

MR: Did your parents think you were pursuing a dead end?

EM: Naa. No, quite the opposite. Because the thing is I never — I always made a buck you know. And I was never the type of kid that was like — you know if I wasn't making music playing, making money playing music, I'd go out and get a job. And so my mom was like a real, like a Eddie Marshall fan.

MR: Oh, that's nice.

EM: I mean this woman was just too much. I mean I would come home, even early there, I'd come home and practice. And I was really gone. Once I got into it I mean I was a maniac, I'd practice all the time. And she was just totally into it. And I'll never forget one night we were at Birdland. I forget who I was with, oh probably with Toshiko. And we were opening for Buddy Rich's band. And so we were up there and I played and everything and I says, "Mom, we're going to sit and listen to Buddy Rich." So we were watching and listening to Buddy Rich and he's killing it. I mean, you know Buddy Rich. And I knew him. So I said, "I want to introduce you to him." And he was always nice to me. And I said, "I'd like you to meet my mom." And the first thing she says, "Well did you hear Eddie play?" And he's like taking it all down and everything. And she said, "Wasn't it a wonderful solo?" And I'm saying, "Mom, please, you know, chill." And I was a little embarrassed. I couldn't believe it. But she was like that. And I have a brother, twenty years younger than me, Ricky, and he's a drummer also. And he started playing and she was the same way with Ricky. And no, I mean I loved it a lot and I wasn't going to do anything else anyhow.

MR: Right. Well it's nice to have that on your side, isn't it.

EM: Oh because I see so many guys that their parents were just like totally against it, this is a bad idea, and I thought boy. But I mean I started playing professionally when I was 14. But it was always with relatives. I had to get home. Even when I worked with Cookie, we had what we used to call the Boss of the Street, Mr. Griffin, who was like in the black mafia or something, you know numbers, writers and all this kind of stuff. And he made sure I got home every night, every night. It was funny. I remember one time — and on the weekends he would let me stop at the soul food restaurant. I said, "Mr. Griffin can we stop?" I remember one night we stopped at this soul food restaurant on Worthington Street and we're sitting there eating, and Mr. Griffin was this great big, he was like six two, a big, big rough guy. And we're sitting there in the restaurant and some guy comes in and he ordered his food and then there's a big fight. And I'll be back mother fucker, and all this stuff like that. The guy goes, and we're getting ready to leave ourselves, he goes and he comes back with a rifle. And you should have seen — even Mr. Griffin — Mr. Griffin grabs me and he pulls me down under the table and everything. And these guys are, you know just arguing and you don't know if this guy's going to shoot the guy or not. And somebody snuck up in back of the guy and grabbed the rifle. And then we just got out of there. But it was so fast. And Mr. Griffin, he was under the table before I was.

MR: He knows how to take care of himself I guess.

EM: Oh man.

MR: Well this has really been a great pleasure, talking to you.

EM: Oh thank you. It's great going over my fabulous life.

MR: You've had one.

EM: Oh boy.

MR: Well I wish you the best of luck.

EM: Well thank you.

MR: And I hope to get to hear you play sometime soon.

EM: Yeah. So where are you based at? You are based in New York?

MR: Central New York.

EM: Central New York.

MR: Yeah, just near Syracuse, near Utica actually.

EM: Boy I used to play what's that Rensselaer Polytech.

MR: Yeah. RPI.

EM: RPI. I have an uncle who is still living, Gilley Roberts, he's a banjo player who played with Louis Armstrong in 1927, and went to Europe with him and everything. Gilley is 104. And one of my other jobs, he was in the family too, it was another band I played in, we had a traditional jazz band. And we worked all the colleges, like all the fancy colleges, Amherst and University of Massachusetts and all the Upstate schools, and just playing trad music. And this was like in the fifties. And we would make like sometimes two hundred and three hundred dollars a week back in those days, playing at those — Rensselaer, what's the famous womens' school that's in — Vassar. And they would lock us in and lock us out. They were so protective of their women.

MR: They kept a tight— right. Well best of luck.

EM: Well I hope this is good, I've got to get going myself.

MR: Yup. All right. Thank you.